RESEARCH QUESTION · FLORENCE, 1494

The Price of *Democracy*

Who really holds power when only some citizens vote?

My question: Could compulsory voting make democracy more representative?

From concentrated influence to broader participation



THE MEDICI FAMILY IN RENAISSANCE ART

Sandro Botticelli, *Adoration of the Magi*, c. 1470–1475 · Uffizi Galleries.

FIRST SOURCE · JOHN STUART MILL

Voting is a *civic duty.*

REPRESENTATIVE GOVERNMENT



A ballot affects more than the person who casts it.

MILL · CHAPTER 10

“It is strictly a matter of *duty.*”

My ethical foundation: democratic rights come with public responsibilities.

ADDITIONAL SOURCE · TIMOTHY J. FEDDERSEN

Why *not* vote?

THE VOTING PARADOX



Individual	Collective
Cost	**Need**
Time & effort	Representation

Rational for one. *Costly for many.*

Feddersen helped me see why participation cannot be taken for granted.

COUNTERARGUMENT · JOHN STUART MILL, ON LIBERTY

Freedom *vs.* Duty

THE OBJECTION



Freedom to abstain

Nonparticipation can itself express a political choice.

vs.

MY RESPONSE



Duty to participate

Require attendance, not endorsement: allow blank ballots and exemptions.

A stronger argument recognizes that *civic duty has limits.*

WHAT I LEARNED

More turnout. *More nuance.*

BEFORE

More voters = *better democracy.*

AFTER · FOWLER, 2013

+24

percentage points in Australian turnout

Participation changes elections — not necessarily their quality.

Feddersen · Oprea · Fowler · Mill: *representation matters, but freedom still matters.*